enemies of the state and deported or imprisoned. The most basic institutions of peasant life – the family, the church, the local community – were terrorised and dismantled. In the name of justice, equality and the will of the people, the collectivisation campaign annihilated anything that stood in its way. In the first two months of 1930 alone, about 60 million peasants in more than 100,000 villages were herded into collective farms.[87] In June 1929, only 4 per cent of Soviet peasant households had belonged to collective farms. By March 1930 the figure had risen to 57 per cent. By April 1937, 97 per cent of households in the countryside had been confined to the 235,000 Soviet collective farms.[88] In just seven years, then, a way of life that had existed for centuries had been replaced by the totalitarian brainchild of a few Moscow bureaucrats.

THE KULAKS

It is worthwhile to delve a little deeper into the history of Soviet collectivisation. For it was a tragedy that bears some resemblance to earlier catastrophes in human history – like the European witch-hunt craze – and at the same time foreshadows some of the biggest dangers posed by twenty-first-century technology and its faith in supposedly scientific data.

When their efforts to collectivise farming encountered resistance and led to economic disaster, Moscow bureaucrats and mythmakers took a page from Kramer's *Hammer of the Witches*. I don't wish to imply that the Soviets actually read the book, but they too invented a global conspiracy and created an entire nonexistent category of enemies. In the 1930s Soviet authorities repeatedly blamed the disasters afflicting the Soviet economy on a counterrevolutionary cabal whose chief agents were the 'kulaks', or capitalist farmers. Just as in Kramer's imagination witches serving Satan conjured hailstorms that destroyed crops, so in the Stalinist imagination kulaks beholden to global capitalism sabotaged the Soviet economy.

In theory, kulaks were an objective socioeconomic category, defined by analyzing empirical data on things like property, income, capital and wages. Soviet officials could allegedly identify kulaks by counting things. If most people in a village had only one cow, then the few families who had three cows were considered kulaks. If most people in a village didn't hire any labour, but one family hired two workers during harvest time, this was a